

False positive

NO, THIS ISN'T ABOUT THE PANDEMIC THAT MANY SEEM TO HAVE FORGOTTEN ABOUT.

Seriously, I'm having trouble convincing the elderly in my family to keep wearing masks when out... and even here in Australia, where I stay, everyone is fed up with the pandemic. People are still dying of Covid here but the general public is just in a shrug and move on mood.

OK I got sidetracked there. My bad.

And no, this isn't about my antivirus either, and how it identified one of my important files as a virus and deleted it. Does that even happen anymore? I can't remember the last time I got a pop-up on my PC telling me I had a virus. Do you?

Ugh, I got side tracked again...

I tend to do that a lot. In fact, this month, my column is dedicated to one of the times I got side tracked, during which I had a minor epiphany of sorts.

I was on a work call on Google Meet with my boss, when I got a phone call. The number said "Suspected Spam". Many use services such as Truecaller to do the same thing, I just use Samsung's default service powered by Hiya, because it's usually pretty reliable here in Australia. I ignored the call, obviously. The same number tried me a couple of more times and gave up. Got to love technology, right?

As it turns out, that was VFS Global calling about an application I'd made to the Indian Embassy for passport services, and there was a problem with my application. They were calling to give me a chance to fix it by providing a fresh application in soft copy, instead of rejecting it. They sent me a rejection by email citing lack of ability to contact me.

Thankfully I was able to call back and do what all of us do when pleading to the authorities in order to save ourselves a lot of time and hassle. I begged, "Please madam, help me!", as I'm sure many others have done before me, and many others will after. Why do we do it? Because it works, and it did for me too, and I was able to send over a soft copy of a correctly filled form.

However, later it got me thinking about why the number came up as "Suspected Spam" in the first place? Why the false positive?

Sadly, I think I know why.

Every single scammer call I get comes from what appears to be a local number, but has a person speaking English with an obvious Indian accent. Sometimes it's so obviously an Indian trying to sound Australian and failing. It's honestly become so bad and so frequent that any call that I get from anyone with an Indian accent, my brain automatically screams "BLOODY SCAMMER!" at me.

I'd once registered a fake name for a survey or something online, over 7 years ago, just to see what would happen (we Digit folk are stupidly curious that way). I used the name Vota Fone as a joke, with my correct phone number. Even today I giggle as scammers and spammers who have scraped my data call me, and go "Hello! May I speak to..." and then there's a pause as they want to say "Vota", or "Mr Fone", and their brain short circuits for a second. All those calls are also made by Indians.

And it's been far worse during the pandemic. I get 3 or 4 calls a day. Others online complain about getting as many as 20 calls a day from scammers, always from different numbers, always spoofed. People are so fed-up, they're just hearing an Indian accent and hanging up the phone, then reporting it as a scam. I should know, twice I've called businesses and their reaction on hearing my accent is "Not interested in your scam mate". One they realise I'm just a customer, they apologise profusely, and give long explanations about why they're not racist, and are just fed up of the calls... and I believe them.

It irks me to get scammers calling me, but it also irks me that so many of my countrymen are making a living out of cheating people across the world out of money. I don't know what kind of person can sleep at night by doing a job like that, but I know it's ruining our reputation globally.

I wish I had tips or a better message here, but I don't. I just do my bit reporting all the scammer numbers more diligently now, sometimes I play along for fun to see what their scam is, because the longer they're on the phone with me the less time they're spending scamming innocent people. Plus the added bonus of wasting their time is that it usually makes them block you! That's a win in my book ;-)



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